The Sisterhood of Bones

(Itinerant order of death nuns)

Winters are harsh, and not everyone who enters the season lives to see its end. When the frost thaws, flocks of white and red nuns descend on the countryside to collect the remains of the poor souls claimed by the cold and the monsters that lurk in it. They strip the pale flesh and clean the bones. They smoke skeletons over pine and incense to help the lost spirits find their way to heaven. They enshrine the remains in the way of their forebears.

The Sisters of Bones are known now as followers of death. Followers not in the sense of being exultant cultists but rather dogged hunters. It is not their charge to alleviate suffering or offer solace. They follow death to sanctify the land it touches, and to dispel the bad luck it brings. In the beginning, this was a task for the spring, but their monolithic presence puts them in demand year-round. Now, whenever someone dies, the Sisterhood of Bones is summoned to give rites to the dead.

Knights of the Mosaic Castle

(Martial order of do-gooders)

They are Legion. Their castle knows as many places as it knows faces, built from stones scraped together from the farthest reaches of the world. The Knights of the Mosaic Castle are a warlike order, but not one built on blood and birthright. They do not swear fealty to a king or a country. Their oaths are to the battered, sun-worn stones they carry—fragments of distant peaks and riverbeds, capstones of archways in crumbling ruins. Each knight carries their own, tied by rope, balanced on shoulders or fastened to backs. Some as heavy as people, some as wide as saddles. These stones together form the mightiest fortress in the world.

When an aspirant comes before the castle gates, they are judged by no other qualities than those of their stone. The castle, a living thing itself woven of the very world it seeks to protect, cares not for status or title. Those who join the order enter as equals, their stones stacked together, a promise of preservation through unity and diversity. In the shadow of the stones, they live by two vows; *to be tough as rock, and to protect all that is given, for it is all we have.*

The Witches of Askania

(Covens of witches living in walking cities)

Wanderers of the high valleys of the northern ways, the Witches of Askania sail the world on the backs of walking cities. Their homes are not rooted in one place, for the land itself whispers in their ears, guiding their migrations through the wandering feet of their cities. The consent of the land is their power, and it is said that to anger one coven is to turn the restless spirits of an entire landscape against you; to invoke an endless shifting of the earth beneath your feet.

The walking cities of Askania are great wonders, churning towers of timber and glass and bone. They are powered by ancient pacts between witch and world. Their walls hum with the pulse of life, bound to the land in a strange, symbiotic dance. In the center of their locomotive joints are communal hearths of steaming copper, singing and breathing and laughing. The witches gather at these hearths to hear the wisdom of their city, and to exchange their knowledge with one another.

Va′a Nomads

(Herders and guardians of the dune sea)

The equatorial sunbelt is a difficult place to make a living, but for the Va′a, there is no fonder home. They alone traverse the endlessly breathing dune sea like gulls in a tailwind. The ingenuity of the Va′a makes their lives possible; clothes designed to ward off heat, jittering torque machines that traverse conditions no pack animal could tolerate. They are a people sustained by the wind, the greatest asset of a desert-dweller. It powers their jitter-walkers, cools their homes, and brings moisture to their cisterns.

From birth, the Va′a are instilled with a quiet reverence for the Dune Sea. It is a uniquely harsh environment filled with secrets, which the Va′a zealously protect. All throughout the shifting sands are scattered ruins and charred outposts, left behind by the *Desert Fathers*. It is said that there exists no greater trove of well-preserved ruins and technology, and there exist no greater custodians than the Va′a, for they have—up to this point—not sought to exploit the power of these ruins to their advantage. It is said they do this both out of respect for the dead, and out of fear; fear that whatever grim fate that befell the Desert Fathers might claim the Va′a as well.

Custodians of Silence

(Shadowy ethicists leading the academic world)

There is a notion among the academics, the scholars, surgeons, and magicians. A notion about *ethics*, as they say, called "*Minding the Gap*." It is a word of warning from the old and wise to the young and ambitious. Some gaps in our knowledge are not meant to be filled. Some gaps exist deliberately. Sometimes, that which is *true* does not align with that which is *good*. And when an idea is passed from academia to the public, it is nearly impossible to undo.

The Custodians of Silence are the final witnesses and wardens of forbidden knowledge. Their charge is not to preserve or destroy truth, but to isolate it. When an academic gains knowledge of a Minding Gap, they are expected to confess this knowledge to the Custodians. Any evidence, or reference to evidence, of a Minding Gap is carefully hidden, obfuscated, and—if needs be—destroyed entirely. What is told to the Custodians is sealed beneath layers of psychic discipline and cultural terror. Their name is spoken rarely, always in a low voice—because their existence acknowledges that some truths are too dangerous to let breathe.

The Courselets

(Crown-chartered merchants and corsairs)

More properly called the Imperial Coursing Guild, the courselets are a centralized network of merchants, navigators, and adventurers put to the task of bringing the goods of far-flung lands back to the cities and citizens of the Morivian Empire. They were originally chartered to map the unknown lands beyond the Sea of Lights and the Dim, but with that task believed to have been completed, the guild has turned its sights away from knowledge and towards wealth.

The Morivian Empire is held together by the promise of wealth and comfort for its citizens, and this promise is principally kept by the Courselets. Their maps chart every coast and river, their offices hold every port, their ships ride every tide and season. Many communities outside of the empire have come to rely on trade with the Courselets for their survival. The Courselets are often even the first point of contact between unknown peoples and the empire. Best be sure, though, if a community has something the empire wishes to possess, the Courselets will find them, and they would do well to make themselves open to offers.